Provincial Mentoring

Provincial Grand Lodge of Hertfordshire

Prepare • Guide • Support • Enlighten

Personal Mentor Course

Two hours of conversation about conversation: the handful of skills that make a Personal Mentor the friend a new Brother needs

Delivered by W Bro Wes Pierce, Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor

By the end of tonight you will be able to

Say what the role is, and is not

In one sentence each, and name where the Almoner and the Lodge Mentor take over

Ask a question that opens a door

Turn a closed question into an open one, and ask it

Listen, and hold a silence

Hear tone and hesitation, and count to three before you speak

Spot trouble early

Recognise the warning signs and say who acts, in what order

Reach for the right tool

The Meeting Guide, the Stage Checklists, the Warning Signs card

Do one thing differently

With your mentee, this month

How tonight works

In the room

- Tables of four; you will move into pairs twice
- Workbook in front of you; write in it
- Flipchart for the things we find together
- Nothing tonight touches ritual
- Phones away unless you are using Solomon

The deal

- I will not tell you how to mentor; I will show you three things and let you try them
- Say what you think, not what you think I want
- If you have been a Personal Mentor for twenty years, you are the most useful person here: say what has worked

1

The story of a man we lost

Where were the moments this could have been turned around?

The story of a man we lost

“I joined at thirty-four, proposed by a colleague I liked. My Initiation was extraordinary; I drove home buzzing. Then came my second meeting: nobody had told me it was mainly business, and I sat at dinner next to two men who talked across me all night about people I didn’t know. At my first rehearsal evening I was told after ten minutes there was nothing for me and I should get off home. Work went mad that spring; I missed two meetings. Nobody rang. When I came back, someone at the bar said, ‘Well, look who’s remembered where we meet.’ Everyone laughed. I laughed too. My subscription renewal came in January with a letter that read like a final demand. I paid it, and then I sat down one Sunday and wrote a different letter. The Secretary’s reply was very polite. It said my resignation had been received and would be reported to the Lodge. Nobody ever asked me why.”

A composite drawn from real losses. Every detail has happened to someone.

Six moments, and none of them needed an expert

1 The second meeting

Nobody said it would be business. Nobody sat with him.

2 The rehearsal

Sent home after ten minutes. “Nothing for you.”

3 Two missed meetings

Nobody rang. The silence was the message.

4 The bar

A joke at his expense. Everyone laughed; so did he.

5 The renewal letter

Read like a final demand. Paid, and then the other letter.

6 The reply

Polite. Received. Reported. Nobody asked why.

All of them required someone noticing. That is the job.

A friend with a purpose

Your role is

- His first point of contact for any question
- Someone who keeps in touch between meetings
- A listener who notices when something changes
- His bridge to the Lodge and the Province

Your role is not

- The only person who can help him
- A ritual coach. That is the Lodge of Instruction
- Someone who monitors or reports on him
- A replacement for the Lodge Mentor, who co-ordinates
- A welfare officer. That is the Almoner, and referring early is the skill, not the failure

The four principles

Defined once, on the Province's canon page, and quoted everywhere. They run together, all the time. They are not stages.

1 PREPARE

Ready for each stage before it happens. There should never be any surprises.

2 GUIDE

Accurate, honest, timely information. Never dependency.

3 SUPPORT

Present, responsive, compassionate. "How can we help?", never "Why aren't you attending?"

4 ENLIGHTEN

Understanding, curiosity and enjoyment of Freemasonry, for life.

Coach, not counsellor. If it touches his health, money, family or safety: Almoner and Lodge Mentor, promptly.

2

Questions that open doors

The difference between “did you enjoy it?” and “what did you make of it?”

Open or closed?

“Did you enjoy the ceremony?”

Invites “yes”. He will say yes whether or not it is true, because you are kind and he does not want to disappoint you.

“What did you make of tonight?”

Invites the truth. He has to think, and what he says will tell you where he actually is.

The test of an open question

You cannot predict the answer. Most mentors ask closed questions out of kindness, to make it easy to answer. The kindness is in the open question, because it says: I want to know what you actually think. Start with what, how, or tell me about; never with did, are, is or have.

Exercise 1: rewrite the six

Pairs · 5 minutes

1 “Did you enjoy the ceremony?”

2 “Are you settling in alright?”

3 “Have you got any questions?”

4 “Are you coming to the next meeting?”

5 “Is the ritual learning going okay?”

6 “Everything alright at home?”

Workbook page 3. Rewrite each so that you could not predict the answer. Compare across the room before the model answers.

Six that work

“Did you enjoy the ceremony?”	→	**What did you make of tonight?**
“Are you settling in alright?”	→	**What has surprised you most so far?**
“Have you got any questions?”	→	**What have you been wondering about that nobody has explained?**
“Are you coming to the next meeting?”	→	**What would make the next few months work well for you?**
“Is the ritual learning going okay?”	→	**How are you finding the learning, and what would help?**
“Everything alright at home?”	→	**How are things generally, with work and home, and how does Lodge fit around it all at the moment?**

Exercise 1, part two: ask it for real

Pairs · 3 min each way

“What did you make of your own Initiation, all those years ago?”

The asker

- Ask it once. Then stop.
- One follow-up question at most
- Notice what he returns to

The listener

- Answer honestly; you were new once
- Notice how it feels to be asked properly
- Afterwards, write one thing your partner said that you would not have guessed

3

Listening, and the three-second rule

What you hear the second time that you missed the first

Sixty seconds of bad listening

Demonstration · 1 min

What you will see

- Interrupting
- Topping his story with a better one
- Filling every pause
- Looking at the door, the bar, the phone
- Answering a question he did not ask

What good looks like

- Listen for tone and hesitation, not only words
- Notice what he returns to, and what he leaves out
- When silence falls, count to three before you speak
- He will usually fill it. What he says then is the real answer
- The awkwardness is yours, not his. He is thinking

Exercise 2: listening only

Pairs · 3 min each way

The listener may say nothing, except to ask one further question.

Same question as before

“What did you make of your own Initiation, all those years ago?” Swap roles from Exercise 1 if you like. Count to three in every silence.

Then write, workbook page 4

What did you hear the second time that you missed the first?

4

Scenarios

Tonight, this week, this month. And who else needs to know

Exercise 3: one scenario per table

Fours · 10 minutes

A The overwhelmed Entered Apprentice

Initiated two months ago. “Honestly, I still haven’t a clue what’s going on in there. Everyone else seems to just know.” Smiling, but he has said it twice.

B The quiet drift

A Master Mason of three years, not your mentee. Two consecutive meetings missed without apology. Subscription unpaid. Passed over for Inner Guard last year.

C The ritual dread

Offered his first office. Barely slept before his Second Degree questions; thinking of saying no. “I’m just not a performer, and I think they’ll think less of me.”

D The eager recruiter

At the bar, a senior Brother to your recently raised mentee: “You’re not a proper Mason till you’ve done the Chapter. I’ll put your name down.” Your mentee looks cornered.

Workbook pages 5 and 6. What do you do tonight, this week, this month, and who else needs to know? Two minutes a table to report back.

Debrief: what good looks like

A The overwhelmed EA

Normalise it. Name the two shocks. Book the one-to-one before the next meeting. Pace the information; Initiate's Guide and Welcome Apprentice, together.

B The quiet drift

Best-placed friend rings within seven days: "you were missed". Treasurer's signal to the Almoner and Lodge Mentor, not round the bar. Under-use named as a cause. Step one of four.

C The ritual dread

Protect him from pressure both ways. No office before ready; explore what ready would need: LoI, a small first piece, a shared office. His contribution is valid with or without ritual.

D The eager recruiter

Rescue in the moment with grace; never embarrass the senior Brother publicly. Afterwards: information, not recruitment; the timing is his; the Royal Arch Representative when he is ready.

The warning signs, and the four steps

The pattern is the signal

- A break in his own pattern, not a low level of attendance
- Two consecutive misses without a word; going quiet; dropping out of LoI; money or time talk; a flat mood at dinner
- One is nothing. A pattern is a conversation

The right question

Always “How can I help?”, never “Why haven’t you been attending?”. The tone decides whether he feels supported or judged. Warm and informal first: a call, a message, a coffee.

1 You

Friendly, informal contact. After two consecutive misses, within seven days of the second.

2 Lodge Mentor

The overview; what could the Lodge itself change; a discreet note; close the loop.

3 Worshipful Master

Where it touches Lodge culture, office or another member. Almoner alongside for welfare.

4 The Province

An impartial voice, or a Lodge where he might thrive. Responsible mentoring, not failure.

5

The tools, and one thing

Where the library lives, and what you will do this month

Reach for the right tool

Personal Mentor’s Short Guide

Five pages. The role, the journey, the conversations, help for you. Read it on the train.

Mentor Meeting Guide

A conversation guide for one-to-ones, stage by stage. Open it before each meeting.

Stage Checklists

One page each: Initiation night, second meeting, before Passing and Raising, Installation, first Lol.

Warning Signs card

The signs and the four steps on a card for your pocket.

Solomon

solomon.ugle.org.uk. Send him there, and go yourself. Welcome Apprentice is the place to start.

People

The monthly call, first Tuesday 7pm on Teams. DAWG. Your Lodge Mentor. The Provincial office, in confidence.

One thing

One thing I will do differently with my mentee this month.

Write it, then say it

Workbook page 8. By when, and how you will know it worked. Then round the room, one sentence each.

You will hear from me

One month from tonight, a message: what did you try, and what happened? It is the habit the course teaches, so I will practise it on you.

Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

Freemasonry must be fun. A man who is enjoying himself attends; a man who attends participates; a man who participates belongs; and a man who belongs does not resign. That is the whole job. Thank you.

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